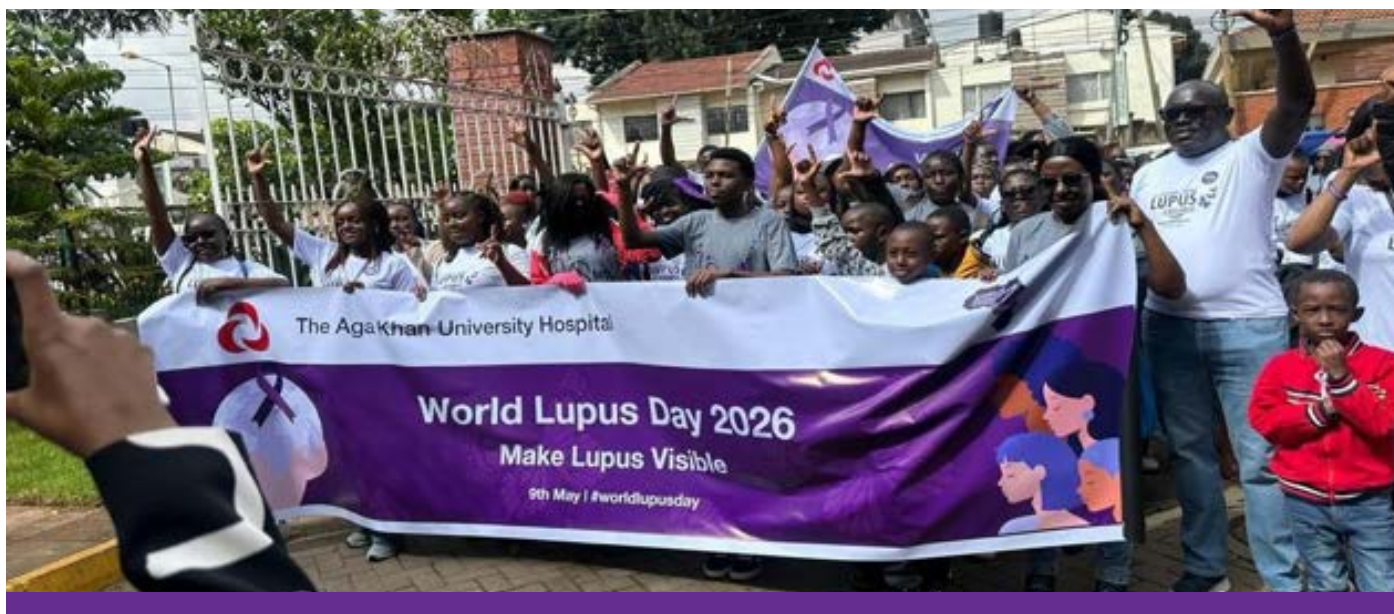


Newsletter

JAN – JUNE 2026

LUPUS FOUNDATION OF AFRICA

FIRST EDITION



STEPS FOR CHANGE

Welcome to the inaugural edition of the Lupus Foundation of Africa (LFA) Bi-Annual Newsletter. As we reflect on the first half of 2026, we are grateful for the progress we have made together and inspired by the resilience, courage, and strength of the lupus community across Africa.



From our leadership: Taking steps together

The World Lupus Day theme, “Steps for Change,” speaks to the meaningful strides we are taking to improve the lives of people living with lupus through advocacy, awareness, education, access to care, community support, and strategic partnerships.

This first edition captures some of the milestones that have shaped our journey over the past six months, from strengthening access to medication and mental health support to commemorating World Lupus Day, promoting nutrition education, building community connections, and amplifying the voices and experiences of people living with lupus and their caregivers.

Each milestone represents more than an achievement. It is a step towards building a stronger, more informed, and better-supported lupus community and towards ensuring that no one living with lupus is left behind.

As we share our journey, we also invite you to be part of what comes next. LFA

believes that lasting change is built through collaboration. We welcome partners, institutions, organizations, healthcare professionals, advocates, and supporters who share our commitment to transforming lupus care and support across Africa.

As you turn these pages, we hope you will celebrate these milestones with us, be inspired by the voices of our community, and see the opportunities for us to take the next steps together.

Together, we are taking steps for change.

LFA IN NUMBERS

LFA in six months; by the numbers

Impact snapshot

Warriors reached with

20+

Medication support

500+

Active community members Mental health platform introduced

1

National policy engagement with SHA

1

Major World Lupus Day community event

1

National media appearances

2

Lived-experience stories amplified

2

People reached through awareness activities.

5000+

Partnerships established: Vimbo, Genetest, MaryBen Foundation

3

SMALL STEPS, INVISIBLE BATTLES: OUR WORLD LUPUS DAY STORY

On 9th May 2026, the Lupus Foundation of Africa and Aga Khan University Hospital marked World Lupus Day. Not just to observe a date. To celebrate **courage, resilience, strength, and community.**



Our theme: Steps for Change. Why “Steps for Change”? Because in the lupus journey, the biggest victories are often the smallest steps.

Through pain, exhaustion, confusion, and brain fog. Through fear of stigma. Through days when the body feels heavier than the spirit. And yet, lupus warriors still rise.

What We Learned

At the heart of our gathering were real people sharing real experiences. What lupus changes physically, emotionally, financially, and spiritually.

The key takeaway?

A strong support system changes everything. Family. Partners. Friends. Colleagues. Community.

That’s why the Lupus Foundation of Africa built a patient support platform. A judgment-free space to share, learn, and journey together.

One thing became clear: **Lupus is not just a medical journey. It’s emotional, financial, mental, social, and deeply human.**

The Hard Truth

Did you know?

Kenya has only **15 rheumatologists** serving over 50 million people. Most are concentrated in Nairobi. Think about that.

On affordability: For many lupus patients, treatment is not just medically demanding; it’s **financially unsustainable.**

We Remember

We paused to honor those

whose journey ended too soon. Those currently hospitalized. Too fatigued to join us. And everyone silently battling an invisible illness.

What Patients Need

- Increase national awareness of lupus.
- Promote early diagnosis and access to care
- Include lupus in the Social Health Insurance Fund (SHIF)
- Strengthen patient support nationwide

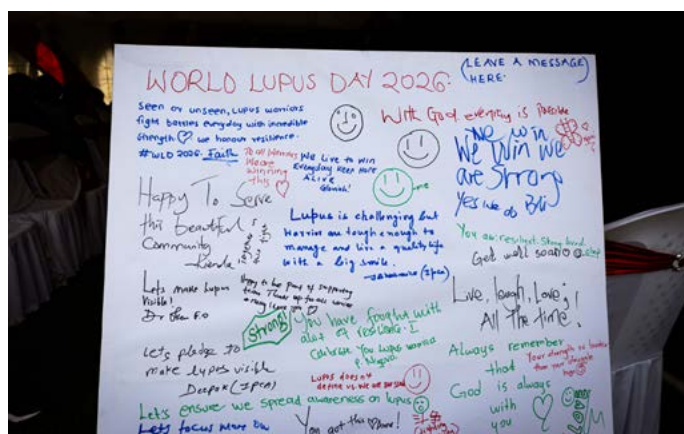
Our Call

Join hands. Talk about lupus. Support someone who feels unseen. People can live and thrive with lupus. With the right conditions, treatment, and support.

To Our Government

- We need early diagnosis.
- Affordable treatment and medication.
- Because with those, many can live fulfilling, productive lives.

Let's make lupus visible. Not just one day; every day.



ONE BIRTHDAY 20+ WARRIORS.

Warrior supporting Warriors

When one lupus warrior chose to turn her birthday celebration into an act of giving, more than 20 warriors across Kenya received medication support.

What better way to celebrate a birthday than by giving someone else a reason to smile?

Our first medication drive for the year was proudly sponsored by a warrior who chose to celebrate her birthday by giving back to her community.



A special shout-out to Chichi for turning a personal celebration into a moment of collective care. Our LFA Warrior Ambassador



People living with lupus, often referred to as 'lupus warriors' in Kenya, continue to face significant challenges in accessing consistent medical care, psychosocial support, and reliable information. Many experience interruptions in treatment due to financial constraints, limited access to services, and emotional strain.

In a powerful act of solidarity, a lupus warrior donated her birthday gift to support fellow warriors. This contribution presented an opportunity to deliver **direct support to lupus warriors** and strengthen **community visibility**. Over 20 warriors received two months' medication support across Kenya. Every package represented more than medication. It carried hope, compassion, and reassurance that no one has

to face lupus alone. This initiative reflects the strength of our community, where lupus warriors continue to uplift one another through generosity, solidarity, and shared understanding. Four warriors' annual Social Health Authority (SHA) payments were completed, providing access to continuous healthcare.

We extend our heartfelt appreciation to Chichi, our warrior ambassador, who chose to celebrate her birthday by supporting fellow warriors through this generous act of giving. Her kindness is a powerful reminder that acts of compassion can make a lasting difference.

Together, we are proving that when warriors stand for one another, lives are changed and hope continues to grow.



A patient receiving the medication from LFA official

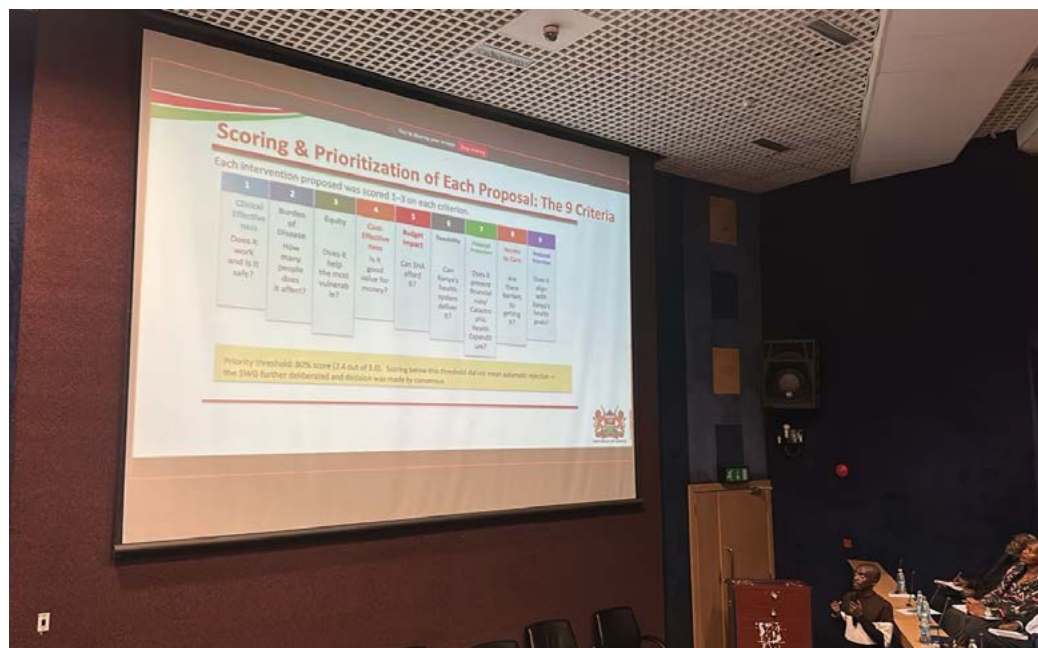
FROM VOICES TO POLICY: ADVOCATING FOR CHANGE

For us, advocacy means turning lived experiences into action.

In the first half of 2026, LFA joined other patient support groups to submit proposals to the Social Health Authority (SHA) calling for greater recognition and inclusion of autoimmune conditions in social health discussions.

We took the conversation directly to the table, engaging SHA stakeholders on a critical question: What will it take to make healthcare more accessible and responsive for people living with Autoimmune Rheumatic Diseases?

There is still work to do. But this is how change begins, with patients at the table, their experiences informing the conversation, and their voices shaping the systems that affect their lives. One proposal. One conversation. One step closer to change.



WHY THIS MATTERS

For people living with lupus, policy decisions can determine whether care is accessible, affordable, and sustainable.

LFA's ask:

- Earlier diagnosis
- Affordable treatment
- Recognition of autoimmune conditions
- Better access to care
- Stronger patient support

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

*Warrior meetup.
A Community That Shows Up. 18 April 2026 | Uhuru Park, Nairobi*

On 18 April 2026, 20+ warriors and caregivers came together at Uhuru Park for an afternoon of connection, shared experiences, and renewed hope.

The meetup created space for members to give, receive, and learn from one another through:

- **Medication sharing;** Members with extra medication extended a helping hand to those who needed it.
- **Peer conversations;** Warriors and caregivers shared their journeys, lessons, challenges, and encouragement.
- **Hope for newly diagnosed warriors;** Hearing from members who have lived with lupus for decades offered reassurance that life

after diagnosis can still hold possibility and purpose. Beyond the activities, the day strengthened something even more valuable: a community where experience becomes wisdom, support becomes strength, and one person's journey can give another the courage to keep going.

OUR VOICES, OUR STORIES

Voices That Shape Our Advocacy

At LFA, lived experience is at the heart of our work. We believe that the voices of those living with lupus and those who care for them have the power to create awareness, challenge misconceptions, and break the stigma surrounding the condition.

We had the privilege of sharing the powerful stories of **Gloria Mugallo**, a devoted caregiver, and **Isabella Mukiri**, a brave lupus warrior.

Their stories remind us that while every lupus journey is unique, no one should have to walk it alone. From the courage and resilience of living with lupus to the everyday realities of caregiving, their voices bring to life the experiences behind the diagnosis.

Because sometimes, the most powerful advocacy begins with simply telling your story; and creating space for others to be heard.



“

My lupus journey has taught me to take life one day at a time, listen to my body, and give myself grace, even when others may not understand what I am going through. At 61, I choose to turn my experience into hope for others. Lupus does not mean life stops. We can still live, thrive, and become a source of strength and hope for others.”

— Isabella Mukiri

Isabella's story is one of resilience, patience, and choosing to keep going despite years of being misunderstood. Born with autoimmune challenges and later diagnosed with lupus, she navigated childhood and adulthood with pain, fatigue, brain fog, allergies, skin complications, and other symptoms at a time when there was little understanding of autoimmune conditions. Watch the full story: <https://vt.tiktok.com/ZS4KNSeBT/> or <https://www.facebook.com/share/v/1Bwrxchx2j/>

National Awareness Creation

Behind every lupus diagnosis is a deeply personal journey often marked by uncertainty, misdiagnosis, delayed answers, and resilience. In our dedication to creating awareness, we share the voices of lupus warriors whose experiences reveal both the barriers that remain and the possibilities that open when people finally receive the right diagnosis, care, and support.



“

Being a caregiver means carrying your own fears while trying to be strong for someone else. There are days when you feel lost, overwhelmed, and even want to break down, but you still have to show up. It is not easy emotionally, physically, or financially. Sometimes, we caregivers need support too. We need someone to listen, to encourage us, and to remind us that we are not alone.”

— Gloria Mugallo

Gloria Mugallo is a caregiver to a 16-year-old lupus warrior diagnosed in 2025. Her family's journey began with fear, uncertainty, and the difficult reality of learning that lupus is lifelong. At times, she felt lost and overwhelmed. Watch Gloria's Full story: <https://vt.tiktok.com/ZS4KrBkPp/> or <https://www.facebook.com/share/v/1L2SyaHw3j/>

A glimpse into Faith's World

For Faith Mohamed, the journey to a lupus diagnosis began in high school and stretched all the way to 2023. Over the years, she was referred from one specialist to another, each treating the symptoms in front of them, but never uncovering what lay beneath. As Faith recalls, *"They would manage the symptoms but never get to the root cause."*

Even after finally receiving answers, access to care remained a challenge. Living in Mombasa meant travelling to Nairobi whenever complications arose to see her rheumatologist or waiting months for a specialist to visit Mombasa. Her story reflects a wider reality: when specialist care is concentrated in major cities, a diagnosis is only the beginning of the journey.

There is, however, hope in the Lupus Registry being developed by Dr. Sheila Achieng of the University of Liverpool. The registry is helping build evidence to understand and address gaps in lupus care. As Dr. Achieng notes, *"Looking at the data from our registry, we are seeing that the timeline for a diagnosis is getting shorter with time as we get more specialists in this field and more awareness about lupus among Kenyan clinicians."* Faith's journey reminds us how far we have come and how much further we still have to go.

A glimpse into Winnie's World

For Winnie Opondo, the road to a lupus diagnosis was long and exhausting. Time and again, she was treated for infections, yet the underlying cause remained hidden. When the diagnosis finally came, it brought more than a medical explanation; it brought relief. *"That diagnosis gave me answers. I was really happy because finally there was a name to what was going on, beyond the African witchcraft inclination."*

Winnie's experience speaks to something many lupus warriors know too well: when medicine cannot explain what is happening, society is often quick to fill the silence with spiritual explanations. A delayed diagnosis can therefore mean years of not only physical suffering but also confusion and misunderstanding.

Today, Winnie is a career woman, a wife, a mother to two beautiful girls, and most importantly, a fierce advocate for people affected by lupus. Her story is a powerful reminder that access to timely, appropriate care is not simply about receiving a diagnosis; it is about preserving possibilities. With the right care, people living with lupus can continue to build careers, nurture families, and live full, meaningful lives. Winnie's journey is proof that a diagnosis should not define the limits of a life; sometimes, it is what finally makes it possible to reimagine the future.

Coping With Lupus: What Patients Can Control



| DAY BREAK | Health n' Lifestyle : Lupus awareness

A glimpse into Victoria's World

For Victoria Kiende, her health struggles began at birth, long before there was a name for what she was experiencing. Her story shines a light on the gaps in paediatric rheumatology and an education system that often leaves chronically ill children misunderstood, unsupported, and struggling to keep pace with their peers.

Her journey also reveals the inequalities within Kenya's healthcare system, particularly the difference between navigating care in Level 6 public hospitals and accessing a private specialist clinic. Beyond healthcare, Victoria speaks candidly about growing up differently abled, wrestling with identity, being misunderstood, and ultimately discovering who she could become.

Her story reminds us that for children with chronic illness, access to the right care is about more than treating disease. It is about protecting childhood, education, dignity, identity, and the possibility of becoming who they were always meant to be.

“
When I was 9, after failing to get a diagnosis, my mother encountered the book 'It's Not Just Growing Pains,' reached out to Cincinnati Children's Hospital, and that's how I was referred to a rheumatologist. Even then, my first visit with my now-doctor was when I was 14.
”



Understanding Lupus: Manifestation & How To Prevent Flare-Ups

BEYOND THE PHYSICAL: MENTAL HEALTH MATTERS

Lupus Came for the Body... We called in backup.

Living with lupus is about more than managing physical symptoms. The uncertainty, fatigue, pain, stigma, and disruption that can come with a chronic illness can also take a toll on **mental and emotional well-being**. For many lupus warriors, the journey can feel overwhelming, and finding the right support is not always easy.

That is why we are excited to welcome **Vimbo Health** as a new partner in the Lupus Foundation of Africa's journey towards more holistic lupus care.

Through this partnership, LFA is introducing our community to the Vimbo Health app, providing access to digital mental health resources, self-care tools, and guided support. It is another way for our community to access support, build coping tools, and feel less alone along the lupus journey.

Why this partnership matters

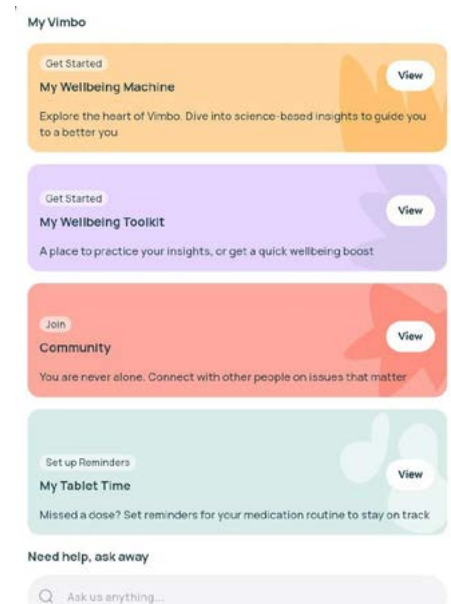
We believe that caring for people living with lupus means caring for the whole person, not just the disease. By bringing mental health support closer to our community, this partnership helps us expand the conversation beyond medication and clinical care to include the emotional and psychological realities of living with lupus.

For LFA, this is more than introducing an app. **It is about creating more avenues for warriors to find support, connection, and tools to navigate the difficult days alongside the good ones.**

We are grateful to Vimbo Health for believing in this vision and partnering with us to strengthen the well-being of the lupus community.

One more step towards holistic lupus care.

One more reminder that no warrior should have to walk this journey alone. This collaboration marks an exciting



step in expanding access to mental health support and creating more ways for our community to feel supported, empowered, and connected. Here's to new partnerships, new possibilities, and a healthier lupus community!

LIVING WELL WITH LUPUS

Nutrition Education

As part of our commitment to empowering the lupus community, the Lupus Foundation of Africa hosted an educational webinar on nutrition led by a professional nutritionist. The session brought together members eager to learn how nutrition can support their health and improve their quality of life while living with lupus.

Through practical advice and an engaging question-and-answer session, participants gained valuable insights into making informed dietary choices and adopting healthier lifestyle habits to manage lupus better.

We extend our sincere appreciation to AAR Health Care and special thanks to Kelvin Njenga for generously sharing his expertise and helping our community understand that living well with lupus begins with making informed choices.



PROTEIN REQUIREMENTS
Adequate intake; adjustments for lupus nephritis and kidney function.
Protein: ~15% to 20% of Total Daily Calories

• Lean protein sources—such as poultry, fish, eggs, and plant-based options (beans, lentils, tofu)—are recommended to maintain muscle mass and support tissue repair. Lupus Nephritis (usually down to 0.6–0.8 grams per kilogram of body weight per day). This minimizes the workload on the kidneys and helps slow down the progression of renal decline.

ONE-DAY MEAL PLAN

Balanced breakfast, lunch, dinner, snacks emphasizing anti-inflammatory foods.

Breakfast	Afternoon Snack
Oats porridge (1½ cups)	Plain yoghurt (1 cup)
1 boiled egg	
1 orange	

Mid-Morning Snack	Dinner
1 banana	Sweet potatoes (250 g)
	Steamed beans (1 cup)
	Steamed spinach (1 cup)

Lunch
Brown rice (1 cup cooked)
Grilled fish (120 g)
Sukuma wiki (1 cup)
Machumori (¼ cup)



PARTNERS MAKING CHANGE POSSIBLE

Change happens when we work together.

From healthcare and mental health support to advocacy, diagnostics, treatment access, and public awareness, our partners are helping us take meaningful steps towards a better lupus journey.

VIMBO HEALTH

Expanding access to mental health support

AGA KHAN UNIVERSITY HOSPITAL

Advancing lupus awareness and amplifying patient voices

MATER HOSPITAL

Supporting wellness and physical health

KENYATTA NATIONAL HOSPITAL

NAIROBI ARTHRITIS CLINIC

THE MARY BEN FOUNDATION

Strengthening mental health support

GENETEST DIAGNOSTIC LIMITED & METROPOLIS HEALTHCARE

Expanding access to laboratory services

IPCA & ACCORD

Working towards more accessible and affordable treatment

AAR HEALTHCARE

Promoting nutrition education and living well with lupus

CITIZEN TV, NTV KENYA & KBC

Amplifying lupus awareness and community voices

THE NEXT STEPS ARE OURS TO TAKE

What we're working towards
LFA has taken meaningful steps in the first half of 2026, but we're not slowing down now. We continue working towards

- Better access to care
- Stronger mental health support
- Policy change
- Greater awareness
- A stronger lupus community

WANT TO WALK WITH US?

Partner with LFA. Support our work. Share our stories. Amplify the voices of people living with lupus.

The second half of the year is already calling, and we are coming with bigger conversations, stronger partnerships, more opportunities for community connection, and an even louder commitment to equitable healthcare and better support for people living with lupus.

We are excited to deepen our partnership and strengthen the partnerships that have carried us this far. We welcome new collaborators who share the same vision: a lupus community that is informed, empowered, supported, and never left behind. So, consider this your little teaser... The journey continues.

And trust us... you'll want to see what comes next.

Until the next edition, keep showing up, keep speaking up, and keep taking those steps for change.

With Gratitude,
Lupus Foundation of Africa

[Website] [Email/ phone number]
[Social media]

A Note From a Warrior

Just because I don't look sick doesn't mean I'm not sick.

Some days I am okay. Some days I am not. And then there are the days that are really, really hard.

There are nights when pain keeps me awake, only for me to wake up exhausted and still have to show up the next day. I push through the fatigue, the brain fog, the pain, and the anxiety. I smile, I work, I laugh, and I carry on. Sometimes because I can, and sometimes because I simply have to.

That is the thing about an invisible illness. You can look perfectly fine while your body is fighting a battle no one else can see.

So, when someone tells you they live with lupus, believe them. Don't judge their illness by how they look. Don't assume that because they showed up today, they must be okay. Sometimes showing up is the biggest victory of the day. Listen to them. Believe them. Support them. Walk with them.

And to my LFA family, thank you for creating a space where I don't have to explain or apologize when my body simply says, "Today, we are staying in bed." I am fortunate to have a strong support system and a family where I am seen, heard, and believed. That kind of support makes the hard days a little lighter.

Lupus may be invisible, but I am not. And neither are the battles we fight.





Believe

*Lupus is invisible, but our strength is not.
Today, we rise in purple - unseen,
but unbreakable.*